WORKING RECORD

Working-session *synthesis*

Founding workshop · May 12, 2026 — where it began.

Founding year (Summer 2026) · Chicago, Illinois Mario Ramos & the La Familia Community Scholarship Committee

Purpose of this document

This is a synthesis of record for the founding workshop of the La Familia Community Scholarship. It captures the vision, the intent behind it, the decisions established, and the near-term plan that came out of the session. It is the first in the sequence of working-session syntheses, preceding the May 19 and June 6 records.

1. What this initiative is

La Familia Community Scholarship is not the founding of something new. It is the formalization of a support layer around something Mario Ramos has already been doing alone for over a decade.

Mario has run a basketball workshop at a Chicago Park District site for more than ten years. Young people enter through that door, some stay for years, some move on to college and elsewhere, and Mario has stayed true to the practice the entire time. Word of mouth brings participants from across the Chicago metropolitan area — a northwest-side base, with reach as far as Hyde Park.

The basketball workshop is the front door. The scholarship is the next room.

The core intent

The deeper read of what Mario is trying to accomplish, established in this session:

- **Extend his presence into the parts of these young people's lives that basketball can't reach.** The scholarship funds college visits, a game, a trip — ways to be present at the moments that shape a trajectory.
- **Invite his community into work he has carried alone.** Friends and family have watched him do this for a decade. Many want in. The small default ask is the on-ramp; the barrier is "do you care," not "can you afford it."
- **Build a learning loop, not a fundraising engine.** The donation cap is a deliberate forcing function for restraint. Better to serve seven young people well than fifty approximately.
- **Honor identity while keeping the door open.** "La Familia" is rooted in heritage and captures how the work feels — like family. "Community" is the promise: no young person is outside the circle, regardless of background.
- **Close the loop on contribution with feeling, not bureaucracy.** Donors are buying the feeling of having participated in something good. Reporting back is a relational gesture, not a compliance artifact.

The true test of success for the founding summer is not dollars raised. It is whether the seven young people felt seen, whether the donors felt proud, and whether the committee is energized to plan the next summer.

2. The name

The committee discussed naming and landed on **La Familia Community Scholarship**.

An earlier candidate ("Mighty LLC connection" / a name tied to that framing) was set aside. "Community" was chosen and defended deliberately: it signals that the initiative is all-inclusive — Black, white, brown, everybody — even though "La Familia" carries a Latino connotation. The inclusivity is the point.

"La Familia" is kept in Spanish throughout all materials.

3. The entity

References to La Familia Community Scholarship as the decision-making body mean **Mario Ramos and the La Familia Community Scholarship Committee**, operating together. Mario is the founder and central relationship; the committee is the working group that brings the initiative into being.

Operating model (founding year)

The initiative is currently **informal** — no LLC, no 501(c)(3), no fiscal sponsor. Contributions are received as friends-and-family transfers under the committee's personal stewardship. Donors in this founding year acknowledge in writing that contributions are not tax-deductible and that no legal structure is yet in place.

Mario's working bandwidth this year: evenings and weekends around a full-time job. The committee carries the legwork; Mario is the connector and relationship anchor.

Committee composition

The committee draws from a deliberate cross-section of Chicago's working communities. The breadth is a founding asset — each member brings a network of trust within their own professional community, which becomes a natural channel for outreach.

- **First responders, active duty:** Rob (CPD), Elliott (CFD)
- **First responders, retired:** Ray Calixto (CPD)
- **Tradesmen:** Munchy, Mario Ramos (founder)
- **Business and technical professionals:** Tony, Rey, Justin, and the strategist supporting the founding-year build-out

The rationale, in Mario's words: when people see this range of backgrounds, it adds confidence; and when members like Elliott and Rob go to their own constituents, the shared professional trust makes participation an easier ask.

4. Who we serve

The participant profile

Participants are young people who have shown up consistently and earnestly through Mario's mentorship. Selection is relational, not credential-based:

- **Consistency** — years of returning to the workshop and the relationship
- **Earnestness** — clear engagement with the work
- **Receptivity** — openness to mentorship and to what the initiative offers

The founding cohort

For Summer 2026, the founding cohort is **seven young people**. These are not aspirational picks — the seven are identified and known to Mario and the committee, and represent the most active and engaged participants currently in the workshop. They span a range of ages and life stages, from high school through college.

The rationale for these seven: they are the most consistent, earnest, and receptive participants. As new participants prove the same over time, the committee will include them. The scholarship is an ongoing practice of recognition, not a closed list.

Geography

Base on the northwest side of Chicago; reach across the Chicago metropolitan area, including Hyde Park. Intentionally not constrained to a single neighborhood — the circle has grown organically through word of mouth.

5. How we help: scholarship channels

Support is disbursed through three channels. The committee — at Mario's discretion — chooses the channel and amount based on each young person's situation. There is no fixed per-student amount and no fixed distribution across the cohort.

1. **Cash to parents** — for students in high school or in college; funds go to the parents or guardians.
2. **Cash to students** — typically for students already in college, managing their own affairs.
3. **Direct payment to vendors** — for specific costs such as college-visit travel or books; the scholarship pays the vendor directly.

Distribution is need-aware and trajectory-aware. A graduating senior weighing college visits has different needs than a younger participant joining the summer trip. Per-student amounts are left to Mario's judgment of the cohort's needs.

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6. Initiatives

Programmatic initiatives

Three programs anchor the founding summer. The intent is presence — being in the moments that shape a trajectory. The transactions are real and will be executed.

- **A game together** — bring the cohort to a live game. Timing: June through early July. Shared experience, shared memory.
- **A summer trip** — take the cohort somewhere they wouldn't otherwise go. Timing: anytime through the summer. Travel as a learning experience.
- **College visits** — visit campuses with students weighing what's next. Timing: June through early July. Travel paid directly to vendors.

Infrastructure initiative

Distinct from the programs, a fourth initiative is operational — it builds the rails the rest of the work runs on.

- **Marketing and outreach infrastructure** — established in this session as a deliberate work-stream. Scope for the founding year is intentionally minimal: a simple one-page landing site donors can be pointed at; a payment-receiving mechanism; the one-pager available as a downloadable PDF; and a small set of shareable assets for committee outreach.
- Out of scope this year: full brand identity, social channels, photo library, video, paid promotion — all summer-two considerations.
- Owner: typically led by a business/technical committee member, not Mario.
- The distinction matters: the programs are *why* La Familia exists; the infrastructure is *how* it operates. Named explicitly so it gets ownership and discipline, but kept in proportion.

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7. Funding model

- **Default ask: $50.** Small enough to be a low barrier, meaningful at scale.
- **Donor ceiling: $1,000** in the founding year. Not a limit on belief — a deliberate scaling constraint to keep the operation intimate and within committee capacity.
- **Cadence: annual, one-time per donor per year.** No monthly recurring solicitation at this stage. The model aligns with summer programming and may evolve in future years.

The cap is intentional. We are starting small so we can learn together — better to do right by seven young people than to scale before we are ready. (An earlier, more restrictive framing of the cap was opened up in discussion: those compelled to give more will not be held back, up to the $1,000 ceiling, but most are asked for $50.)

The warm-lead reality

A meaningful number of warm leads already exist — friends and family who have responded positively to early conversations and indicated willingness to contribute. These have **not yet been formally captured** (no contact list, no commitment amounts, no acknowledgments). Building the capture mechanism is the most urgent near-term operational priority. The initiative should be positioned as already having a following of warm leads, with structure built to bring them into the flow.

Why the cap matters

Open caps create operational obligations. A large gift must be received, acknowledged, stewarded, and reported on at a level commensurate with the gift — and the founding-year committee is not yet built for that. The cap is a promise to ourselves not to over-extend before we are ready. Should larger investors emerge (the $4,000–$6,000 range was discussed), that is the kind of trigger that would prompt bringing in formal legal structure.

8. Donor experience: close the loop

Donors are not buying a tax receipt or a guaranteed outcome for a specific child. They are buying participation in something good — the feeling that their contribution reached a young person and that the work is real.

The commitment: **close the loop, with intent and without bureaucracy.**

- **On receipt** — personal acknowledgment from Mario or a committee member, not a form letter; includes the friends-and-family sign-off.
- **Mid-summer** — an update on where contributions went and what the young people are doing; photos when consent allows.
- **Post-summer** — the story of the summer: what worked, who grew, what's next.

Operational restraint is explicit: roughly two updates over the summer, reused templates, stories and photos gathered as they happen rather than manufactured. The feeling comes from authenticity and care, not volume. The loop is closed without over-encumbering operations.

9. Path to formalization (future)

Formalization is anticipated for the second and third summers, triggered by larger donor commitments (the $4,000–$6,000 range) or operational complexity beyond what informal operation can absorb. Options to evaluate when the time comes: a direct 501(c)(3), fiscal sponsorship under an existing nonprofit, or an LLC with a donor-advised vehicle. Founding-year recordkeeping is designed to survive that transition without rework.

Compliance is tracked as a separate thread: donor friends-and-family sign-off language, minor permission and release forms for trips, and recordkeeping discipline.

10. Deliverables established in this session

Three core artifacts were commissioned and produced as first drafts:

1. **One-pager** — vision, mission, and a plain write-up of the initiative; external-facing and usable as a donor leave-behind.
2. **Committee deck** — concise, attractively styled presentation orienting committee members to the big vision and near-term initiatives.
3. **Strategy and game plan** — the complete working document: vision, objectives, initiatives, roles and alignment (committee, donors, students/families), near-term milestones, path to formalization, and open questions.

A **scholarship application** was scoped as a placeholder, to be developed in a follow-up session — capturing what each participant is committing toward in exchange for the scholarship.

Design system for all public-facing materials: Fraunces/Georgia plus DM Sans/Calibri typography; a bone/cream, terracotta-clay, navy, and gold palette; mobile-first rendering.

11. Near-term milestones (as set in this session)

The runway is tight: roughly four weeks from this session to scholarship delivery.

- **Scholarship application deadline:** June 1
- **Funds in hand:** early June
- **Scholarships delivered:** mid-June, in person where possible
- **Initiatives executed:** game and college visits in June–early July; trip anytime through summer
- **Donor updates:** mid-summer note, then post-summer recap

Immediate priorities established:

- Stand up a single donation receiving channel, controlled by Mario
- Capture the existing warm leads into a ledger before they decay
- Draft the donor ask script and acknowledgment / sign-off language
- Stand up the minimal marketing and outreach infrastructure
- Confirm the seven in writing; collect intake/applications and permissions

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12. Open questions carried forward

- Specific dates and venues for the game, trip, and college visits
- Per-student scholarship amounts and channel selections for the seven
- Payment mechanism decision: personal channels (Zelle, dedicated account), a consumer donation platform, or a combination
- Whether to develop a small visual identity beyond what is implicit in the founding artifacts
- The scholarship application content
- Scholarship application return timeline vs. the fundraising close window — requires Mario and facilitator alignment

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